INCH-POUND

FED-STD-123J
19 May 2021

SUPERSEDING
FED-STD-123H
August 8, 2007

FEDERAL STANDARD

Marking for Shipment (Civil Agencies)

The General Services Administration has authorized the use of this federal specification by all federal agencies.

Section 1: Scope and Classification

1.1 Scope. This document establishes requirements for marking of unit, intermediate, transport packages, and unit loads for shipments of purchased commodities (items) from government contractors or vendors to ordering civil agency activities. Marking requirements of this standard apply only for shipments to civil agencies and GSA retail operations.

1.2 Application. Civil agencies may reference this standard in the preparation of commodity specifications, purchase descriptions, purchase or delivery orders, contracts and other purchase documents to ensure inclusion of complete marking requirements and clear instructions to contractors for the application of markings.

Section 2: Applicable Documents

2.1 General. The following documents form a part of this description to the extent specified herein. Unless a specific issue is identified, the issue in effect on the date of invitation for bids or request for proposal shall apply.

2.1.1 Specifications, standards, and handbooks. The following specifications, standards, and handbooks form a part of this document to the extent specified herein.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE STANDARDS

MIL-STD-129	-	Standard Practice for Military Marking for Shipment and Storage

(Copies of this documents are available online at https://quicksearch.dla.mil

FSC: PACK

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

2.2. Other Government documents, drawings, and publications. The following other Government documents, drawings, and publications form a part of this document to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise specified, the issues of these documents are those cited in the solicitation or contract.

CODE OF FEDERAL REGULATIONS

Title 29 CFR	-	Labor
Title 49 CFR	-	Transportation

(Copies of this documents are available online at https://www.gpo.gov/)

DEFENSE STANDARDIZATION MANUALS

DOD 4120.24-M	-	Defense Standardization Program (DSP) Procedures
DOD 4140.27-M	-	Shelf-Life Management Manual.

(Copies of this documents are available online at https://www.dtic.mil/whs/directives/corres/pdf/412024.pdf)

2.3 Non-Government Publications.

ASTM D5445	-	Standard Practice for Pictorial Markings for Handling of Goods.

(Copies of ASTM publications are available online at www.astm.org.)

INTERNATIONAL STANDARDS ORGANIZATION (ISO)
INTERNATIONAL ELECTROTECHNICAL COMMITTEE (IEC)

ISO 15394:2017	-	Packaging - Bar code and two-dimensional symbols for shipping, transport and receiving labels.
ISO/IEC 15416:2016	-	Automatic identification and data capture techniques - Bar code print quality test specification - Linear symbols
ISO/IEC 16388:2007	-	Information Technology – Automatic Identification and Data Capture Techniques - Code 39 Bar Code Symbology Specification

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

(Application for copies should be addressed to www.iso.org.)

INTERNATIONAL AIR TRANSPORT ASSOCIATION (IATA)

Dangerous Goods Regulations (DGRs)

(Application for copies should be addressed to https://www.iata.org/en/publications or IATA Regional Office for the Americas, 703 Waterford Way (NW 62nd Avenue) Suite 600, Miami, Florida - 33126

INTERNATIONAL CIVIL AVAIATION ORGANIZATION (ICAO)

Technical Instructions for the Safe Transportation of Dangerous Goods by Air

(Application for copies should be addressed at http://www.iata.org; http://www.icao.int or e-mail sales@icao.int or through the International Civil Aviation Organization, Attention: Document Sales Unit, 999 Robert-Bourassa Boulevard, Montreal, Quebec, Canada H3C 5H7.)

INTERNATIONAL MARITIME ORGANIZATION

International Maritime Dangerous Goods (IMDG) Code

Application for copies should be addressed to International Maritime Organization, www.imo.org, info@imo.org or International Maritime Organization 4 Albert Embankment, London SE1 7SR, England.)

2.4 Order of Precedence. Unless otherwise noted herein or in the contract, in the event of a conflict between the text of this document and the references cited herein, the text of this document takes precedence. Nothing in this document, however, supersedes applicable laws and regulations unless a specific exemption has been obtained.

Section 3: Requirements

3.1 Unit Package: the first tie, wrap, or container applied to a single item, a quantity of the same item, a set, or an item with all its component parts. The unit package constitutes a complete and identifiable package containing the unit of issue of a product for ultimate use.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.2 Shipment Unit. A shipment unit has a unique tracking number. It may be divided into partial or split increments for movement on different conveyances; and it can be of a single line item of supply destined to one consignee; or, of multiple line items having the same consignee/destination, shipped together in the same package, or the same conveyance, or as loose packages banded together into a single piece; or, it can be of multiple shipment units aggregated into a consolidated shipment unit.

3.3 Intermediate Container or Package: a wrap, box, or bundle (that is, a container) that contains two or more unit packages of identical items

3.4 Transport or Exterior Package: A shipping container or package used to protect goods during the process of distribution (handling, storage and transportation). A container that is sufficiently strong to be used in commerce for packing, storing, and shipping commodities, such as a box, barrel, crate, or drum.

3.5 Unit Load: unitized load in packaging, consisting of articles or containers secured together so as to be handled as an entity. In distribution, an item or assembly of items assembled or restrained for handling and transportation as a single entity such as a palletized unit load fixed to a pallet.

3.6 Human Readable Interpretation (HRI) or In-the-Clear Wording: An exact, literal interpretation of the encoded Barcode data presented in a human-readable font without hyphens. Note: HRI is usually found directly under the Barcode data.

3.7 Item name (Nomenclature): The exact name and description of an item as it appears in the contract, purchase order or requisition shall be shown.

3.8 Purchase Order number (PO): A series of letters and numbers assigned to the purchase agreement between the vendor and FAS.

3.9 Packing List: The packing list identifies the contents of products contained in the transport package. DD Form 1348 may be used as a requisition request and packing list. The packing list normally contains a requisition number (REQN), order number or ticket number as appropriate to the method of sale.

3.10 Shelf life marking. Shelf life marking should be shown as part of the item identification data on unit, intermediate, and transport packages or containers, and unpacked items. Shelf life marking should include the lot or batch number and the manufactured, cured, assembled or packed date (apply one date), and the expiration or inspect/test date, as appropriate. Shelf life marking is based on shelf life codes (SLCs) listed in DoDI 4140.27-M. There are two types of shelf life items. Type I items have a definite non-extendible period of shelf life. They are assigned alpha SLCs (excluding “X”). Type II shelf life items have an assigned shelf life time period that may be extended after completion of visual inspection, certified laboratory test, or restorative action. Type II items are assigned numeric SLCs and

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

"X". Items that are assigned a SLC of zero (non-deteriorative) do not require shelf life marking. Additionally, SLCs, normally specified in the Item Purchase Description (IPD), apply to products identified with National Stock Numbers (NSNs) only.

3.11 Transportation control number (TCN). The single standard shipment identification number for all DoD-sponsored movements (i.e., materiel and equipment and all vendor-shipping transactions involving DoD materiel). The TCN is a 17-position alphanumeric data element assigned to control shipment units through the transportation system which includes domestic and export shipments entering the Defense Transportation System (DTS) and commercial systems).

3.12 Quantity and Unit of issue (UI): The UI is a standard or basic quantity that is expressed as a unit and indicated in a requisition, contract, or order as the minimum quantity issued (bottle, can, dozen, each, foot, gallon, pair, pound, yard, etc.) and to which a unit price is ascribed. There are two types of UI:

a) Definitive UI. A definitive UI is a type of UI designation that indicates an exact quantity of volume, linear measurement, weight, or count (e.g., assembly, each, kit, set, foot, pound, gallon, etc).

b) Non-definitive UI. A non-definitive UI is a type of UI designation that does not indicate an exact quantity of volume, linear measurement, weight, or count (e.g., can, box, or roll). When a non-definitive UI is specified, it is usually accompanied by a UI quantitative expression (e.g., 1 RO (150 ft.) or 1 RL (50 ft.).

3.13 Palletized Unit Load: A quantity of items, packed or unpacked, arranged on a pallet in a specified manner and secured, strapped, or fastened on the pallet so that the whole palletized load is handled as a single unit. A palletized or skidded load is not considered to be a shipping container.

Section 4: Quality Assurance Provisions

4.1 General Marking. Marking shall be in English, clear, legible, permanent, non-fading and sufficient to withstand exposure to weather and handling conditions. Marking materials shall be water resistant and of waterproof grade. Marking may be painted, printed, stenciled, engraved, or labeled on the package. Labels shall be pressure-sensitive and of a water-resistant grade material, coated on one side with water-insoluble, permanent type adhesive capable of .adhering to package surfaces under high and low temperatures. Labels shall have a finish suitable for printing and writing on with ink without feathering or spreading, and be capable of withstanding normal handling and storage conditions. Labels and tags shall be securely attached to the item or package when the surface will not support the necessary marking. Separate tags shall be used for identification and address marking. Marking shall be

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

located on at least one side or face of the package. The preferred side or face is the end panel, but any of the four faces may each display the complete marking requirements. Required marking shall be orientated in a palletized load so that it is visible to the handler. Transport packages and unit loads shall not be marked on the top or bottom of the package or load. Marking shall be in capital letters of equal height, clearly visible, and the largest size practical for the package size within the acceptable range. Regulated material, such as hazardous material, shall be marked in accordance with those requirements as applicable to the mode of transportation. The marking order sequence in section 5 shall be preferred, but not mandatory. Marking not applicable to the shipment shall be obliterated.

4.2 Barcode Marking. Bar coded information shall be accomplished using the application of linear (Code 39) symbols in accordance with ISO/IEC 16388. Print quality, element width, and wide to narrow ratios will comply with ISO/IEC 15416 and ANSI MH10.8.1. Barcoded information shall be capable of being interpreted by a scanning device, including through material such as stretch wrap. Packages too small to accommodate a barcode need not display a barcode.

4.3 Hazardous Material (HAZMAT or HM) Marking and Labeling. Depending on the mode of transportation, HM shall be marked and labeled in accordance with Title 49 CFR, Parts 171-180, ICAO Technical Instructions for the Safe Transportation of Dangerous Goods by Air, IATA DGRs, or the IMO IMDG Code for water shipments, as applicable. Proper shipping names (PSNs), United Nations (UN) HAZMAT identification numbers, HAZMAT classification warning labels, a chemical warning label as specified in Title 29 CFR, Part 1910.1200, Hazard Communication Standard and UN Performance-Oriented Packaging certification marking shall be placed on the transport package, as required. (See Figure 3)

4.4 Shelf Life Marking. National Supply System shelf life items shall be marked with the lot or batch number, as applicable, and the date of manufacture, cure, assembly, or pack and the date of expiration for non-extendible Type I items and the re-inspection or test date for extendible (Type II) items.

4.5 Special Marking. When the contract or purchase order (PO) requires special marking information such as the requisition number (REQN), priority code (PRI), project code (PROJ), required delivery date (RDD), contract number (CON), or transportation control number (TCN), the required data shall be applied on the package and shall be preceded by the abbreviation shown herein. This data may be integrated with other data on the vendor's commercial shipping label or may be displayed on a separate label next to it.

4.6 Marking for Overseas Shipping. Marking of shipments to civil agencies in overseas, processed through a Department of Defense (DoD) consolidation and containerization point (CCP), or aerial port, or entering the Defense Transportation System (DTS), shall be marked per MIL-STD-129 and labeled with a Military Shipping Label (MSL), or a similar label that depicts the required information on the MSL. Shipping to diplomatic missions through the State

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Department processed through a Consolidation Receiving Point (CRP) shall have the Ship To/Mark For, and the (REQN) annotated on the label.

4.7 Handling, Caution, and Pictorial markings. Transport packages shall be marked with the appropriate pictorial symbols or caution prints directly applied to the package, or on labels, tags, or any other suitable method such as stamping or stenciling. This includes words such as "Do Not Drop", "Do Not Stack", "Fragile", "Keep Frozen", "This Side Up", "Fragile", "Keep Frozen". See ASTM 4554 for Examples of these special handling pictorials.

4.8 Commercial Packing Lists and Shipping Documentation. The vendor shall include a packing list with the shipment. Attachment shall be consistent with standard commercial practice.

Section 5: Packaging

5.1 Unless specifically exempted in the contract, marking of products in packages identified by National Stock Numbers (NSNs) normally ordered and fulfilled through the National Supply System shall be as follows:

5.1.1 Unit and Intermediate Packages shall be marked with the identification text information on one side of the package, as listed. Unit packages used as transport packages shall be marked in accordance with 5.1.2.

(a) NSN or P/N, as applicable in HRI and in linear Barcode (barcode optional)
(b) Item name (nomenclature), see section 3.7
(c) Quantity and unit (e.g., 10EA, 1 DZ, 4LI, 12 KT, etc.), see 3.12
(d) Contractor's name and address including zip code
(e) Shelf life (SL) marking, if applicable, see 3.10.
(f) Hazardous material (HM) marking, if applicable, see 4.3 and Figure 3.
(g) Handling, caution, and pictorial markings, if applicable, see 4.7.

5.1.2 Transport Packages (aka exterior or shipping containers) shall be marked with the identification information of 5.1.1 and the address information indicated below. The address marking can be printed on a separate label (called a shipping label) or can be printed below, next to, or combined with the identification text information (see Figure 2):

(a) REQ, PO, or CON, as applicable, in HRI (barcode is optional)
(b) Consignor (or ship from) name and address (if other than contractors).
(c) Consignee (or ship to/mark for) name and address.
(d) Piece Number ___of ___total pieces.
(e) Gross Weight in pounds and cubic volume in inches of package

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

(f) Special marking, if applicable, see 4.45.
(g) Handling, caution, and pictorial markings, as applicable (see 4.7)

5.1.3 Transport packages in palletized or unitized load shall be marked with identification and address information of 5.1.1 and 5.1.2 on the transport packages but shall have two labels affixed on adjacent sides of the load with the following information:

(a) Number of transport packages in palletized or unitized load.
(b) REQ, PO, and CON, as applicable, and in barcode (barcode optional)
(c) NSN in HRI and in Barcode format (barcode optional)
(d) Consignor and consignee name, address, and zip code information, except that the consignor and consignee names may be omitted from each Transport package when two labels are affixed on adjacent sides of the palletized load (see Figure 1).
(e) Weight and cube measurements of load

5.1.4 Transport Packages when consolidated into Unit Loads Moving in full Truckload or Carload Shipments containing one stock (NSN) shall be marked as specified in 5.1.1 and 5.1.2, except that the shipping label with the consignor and consignee information are not required on either transport packages or unit loads; instead, it shall be located on two unit loads closest to the door of the truck or carload shipment.

5.1.5 Transport Packages or Palletized loads for mixed stocks (multiple NSNs), in lieu of the identification information, may be marked with:

(a) Brief description of contents (spare parts to NSN XXX) if the items are related.
(b) The word “MULTIPACK” and the gross weight, if the items are not related. Each package within the multipack transport package shall be marked with all identification information specified in 5.1.1.
(c) The words “CONTAINS SHELF-LIFE ITEMS”, if package contains SL items.
(d) The word “OVERPACK” or “AIR ELIGIBLE”, if package contains HM.
(e) The words “MULTIPLE AACs”, if package contains items to a single destination for multiple consignees.
(f) Any special marking per 4.5, if applicable.
(g) Any handling, caution, or pictorial marking (i.e., Fragile, arrows, hazardous warning labels), if applicable.

5.2 Unless specifically exempted in the contract, marking of products in packages normally identified by Part Numbers and ordered and fulfilled through the Federal Supply Schedules shall be as follows:

5.2.1 Identification Text Marking. Marking of Unit, intermediate, and transport packages, unit loads, palletized unit loads, and loose or unpacked of NON-NSN products shall

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

require no additional identification text marking other than the vendors or manufacturers own marking, barcoding, and labeling. Normally, this marking is consumer ("pleasing to the eye") type of marking already printed or painted on the package.

5.2.2 Address Marking. Vendors shall apply a shipping label on transport packages and loads that show at least the SHIP FROM/TO names and addresses. Any additional information such as those shown in 5.1.2 through 5.1.5 shall be recommended but not required.

5.3 Exceptions and waivers to marking requirements. When determined to be in the best interest of the government, the marking requirements on each transport package may be waived by the Office of Acquisition Operations. This exception to the normal marking requirements shall be coordinated with the responsible Supply Center Acquisition Branch. The exceptions and waivers to the marking requirement in accordance with this document shall be included in the Item Purchase Description to take affect.

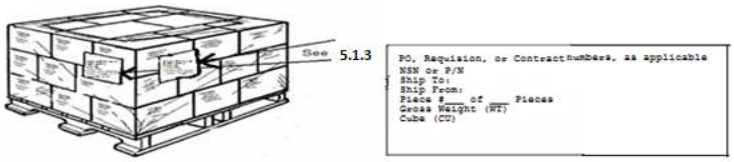


FIGURE 1. PALLETIZED LOAD LABELS

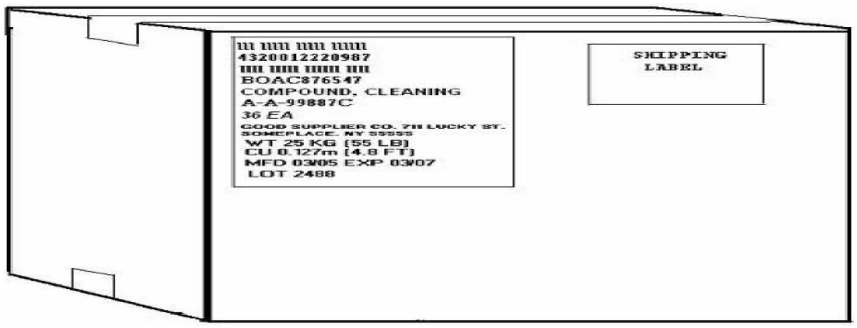


FIGURE 2. TRANSPORT PACKAGE WITH MARKING IN THE PREFERRED ORIENTATION

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

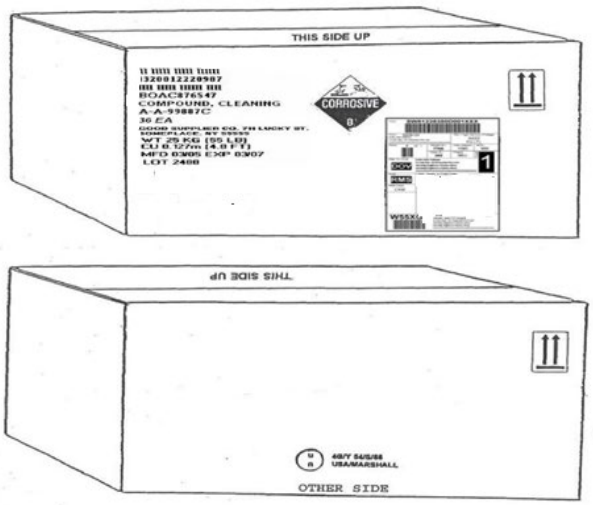


FIGURE 3. HAZMAT MARKING AND LABELING ON A TRANSPORT PACKAGE

Sections 6: Notes

(This section contains information of a general or explanatory nature that may be helpful, but is not mandatory.)

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

CONCLUDING MATERIAL

Custodians:
Other – FAS

Preparing Activity:
Other – FAS

(Project: PACK – 2020–009)

Review Activities:
Army – AV, CR, MI, MT, PT, SE,
Navy – AS, CG, EC, MC, SA
Air Force –11, 13, 99
DLA – DH, GS3

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T12:53Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.